

FREE TOOL FROM STOP THE LOOP

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THE 5-MINUTE *Daily Reset*

Three micro-practices that interrupt overthinking before it takes hold — morning, midday, and evening.

"The thought is not the truth."



"The goal isn't a quiet mind. It's a freer one."

Overthinking rarely announces itself. It creeps in — a thought that loops back, a decision that won't stay made, a morning that starts with your mind already running. These three practices are designed to interrupt that pattern at the moments it's most likely to start. Each takes under two minutes. None require silence, solitude, or special equipment. They just require that you actually do them.

THE THREE PRACTICES

The *Morning Reset*

The first thing you give your attention to in the morning shapes the baseline state of your nervous system for hours afterward. This practice takes 90 seconds and sets your mind up to engage the day from a grounded place rather than a reactive one.

→ **5 slow exhales.** Breathe in through your nose, then exhale slowly through your mouth — making the out-breath longer than the in-breath. This directly activates your parasympathetic nervous system and measurably lowers your resting arousal before the day begins.

→ **Name 3 things you can see.** Actually look — notice something small you wouldn't normally pay attention to. This anchors your attention in the present moment rather than the ruminations of yesterday or the worries of today.

→ **Ask one question.** "What is one thing I can release today that I have no control over?" You don't need to answer elaborately. Just let something surface — a worry, a rehearsed conversation, a decision you're still carrying — and acknowledge quietly that it does not need your attention right now.

The *Midday Check-In*

By mid-afternoon, most overthinkers have accumulated several loops without realizing it — a conversation they're still processing, a decision they're re-examining, a worry they have been carrying in the background. This two-minute check-in interrupts that accumulation before it reaches evening.

→ **Notice where your mind has been.** Not with judgment — just honestly. Have you been present in what you were doing, or have you been somewhere else? Naming it creates the first moment of distance from it.

→ **Name any loop that's been running.** "I've been thinking about [the email / the conversation / the decision] repeatedly, and I haven't gotten any new insight from it." That acknowledgment — honest and neutral — is often enough to loosen the loop's grip.

→ **Quick body scan.** Where are you holding tension? Jaw, shoulders, hands? Release what you can without forcing anything. Your body has been holding the morning's accumulated stress — let it down slightly before the afternoon begins.

The *Evening Wind-Down*

Nighttime is where overthinking does its most visible damage. When the day quiets and external demands disappear, internal noise gets louder. This practice gives unresolved thoughts a place to go — so your mind isn't carrying them into sleep.

- **Write down anything unresolved.** Not to solve it — to externalize it. Research on the Zeigarnik effect shows that the mind holds unfinished items in active memory. Writing them down signals the brain that they have been registered, and it can release them from active attention.
- **Close the loops you can.** Review what you wrote. Some of it can be addressed tomorrow with a single action. Note that action beside the item. Others cannot be resolved yet — acknowledge those and set them aside deliberately, not with frustration but with intention.
- **Name one thing you handled well today.** Not to perform gratitude — to give your brain accurate data. Overthinkers tend to over-register what went wrong and under-register what went right. One intentional moment of noticing something you did well corrects that bias, gradually, over time.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

These practices work not because they're complicated, but because they're consistent. The neural pathways that drive overthinking strengthen through repetition — and they weaken the same way. Every time you catch a loop early and redirect your attention, you're doing something real at a biological level. Not dramatic. Not instant. But real, and cumulative.

QUICK REFERENCE – THE FULL DAILY PRACTICE AT A GLANCE

MORNING

Before your phone

5 exhales → 3 things you see → 1 thing to release

MIDDAY

Natural transition

Where has your mind been? → Name the loop
→ Body scan

EVENING

30 min before sleep

Write unresolved → Close what you can → Name one win

BONUS – WHEN A LOOP STARTS RIGHT NOW

Name. Breathe. Return.

When a thought starts looping in the middle of your day: **name it** ("there's that thought again") → take **one slow exhale** → **return** your attention to what you were doing. The whole thing takes 15 seconds. Done consistently, it's one of the most effective habit changes in this entire book.

FROM THE BOOK

Stop the Loop

A Psychiatrist's Guide to Quieting Your Mind

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